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Dhanusha Gokulan/Gulf News

SHARJAH UNVEILS FLYING CAR TO BEAT TRAFFIC SNARLS

Sharjah showcased a \$800,000 car that can fly from Abu Dhabi to Muscat in 2 hours 20 minutes. The PAL-V Liberty, known as the world's first real flying car due to the combination of a gyroplane and a vehicle, gives commuters looking to avoid congested roads a futuristic option, while enhancing travel flexibility. With a flight range of 500km and a maximum airspeed of 180km/h, the Liberty shortens commute and travel times.

SEE ALSO P5

Webb telescope detects strongest 'hints' yet of life on distant planet

Two chemicals indicating life detected on planet K2-18b

PARIS

Astronomers announced yesterday that they had detected the most promising "hints" of potential life on a planet beyond our solar system, though other scientists expressed scepticism.

There has been vigorous debate in scientific circles about whether the planet K2-18b, which is 124 light years away in the Leo constellation, could be an ocean world capable of hosting microbial life, at least. Using the James Webb Space Telescope, a British-US team of researchers detected signs of two chemicals in the planet's atmosphere long considered to be "biosignatures" indicating extraterrestrial life.

On Earth, the chemicals dimethyl sulphide (DMS) and dimethyl disulphide are produced only by life, mostly microscopic marine algae called phytoplankton.

The implications could be huge, according to Nikku Madhusudhan, a Cambridge University astrophysicist and lead author of the study, published in The Astrophysical Journal Letters. "Frankly, I think this is the closest we have come to seeing a feature that we can attribute to life," he told journalists.

More than eight times the mass of Earth and 2.5 times as big, K2-18b is rare among the roughly 6,000 exoplanets discovered so far in that it orbits its star in a habitable or "goldilocks" zone.

— AFP

40 killed as Israel targets Gaza camps

HAMAS SAYS RESPONSE TO ISRAELI TRUCE OFFER ALMOST READY

GAZA

Gaza's civil defence agency said yesterday that a series of Israeli air strikes killed at least 40 people, most of them in encampments for displaced civilians, as Israel pressed its unrelenting military offensive in the Palestinian territory.

The Israeli military did not immediately comment, but said it was looking into reports of the strikes, which came as Hamas officials said internal deliberations on the latest Israeli truce offer were nearly complete.

Civil defence spokesman Mahmud Bassal said two Israeli missiles hit several tents in the Al Mawasi area of the southern city of Khan Younis, resulting in at least 16 deaths, "most of them women and children, and 23 others were wounded".

Survivors described a large explosion at the densely packed encampment that set multiple tents ablaze.

Exploding tent

"We were sitting peacefully in the tent, under God's protection, when we suddenly saw something red glowing — and then the tent exploded, and the surrounding tents caught fire," Israa Abu Al Rus told AFP.

"This is supposed to be a safe area in Al Mawasi, and the place just exploded. We fled the tent

After Israel declared Al Mawasi a safe zone in December 2023, tens of thousands of Palestinians flocked to its sand dunes along the Mediterranean coast.

towards the sea and saw the tents burning."

After Israel declared Al Mawasi a safe zone in December 2023, tens of thousands of Palestinians flocked to its sand dunes along the Mediterranean coast seeking refuge from Israeli bombardment.

But the area has since been hit by repeated Israeli strikes, which have exacted a heavy civilian death toll. Bassal said that Israeli strikes on two other encampments of displaced Gazans killed a further nine people — seven in the northern town of Beit Lahia, and a father and son near Al Mawasi.

Separately, the civil defence agency reported two more attacks on displaced people in Jabalia — one that killed at least seven members of the Asaliya family, and another that killed six people at a school being used as a shelter. The agency also reported two people killed by Israeli shelling in the Shujaiya neighbourhood of Gaza City.

— AFP

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